

The Implications of User-Generated Content Websites for Tourism Marketing

by

Irina Albăstroiu, Mihai Felea

The Bucharest University of Economic Studies, Romania

irina.albastroiu@com.ase.ro, mihai.felea@com.ase.ro

Abstract. User-generated content (UGC) is the basis for information sharing and collaboration over the Internet and these Web 2.0 tools have changed the ways that travelers search for, view and evaluate travel information. In marketing terms, UGC sites are effectively a form of “consumer to consumer marketing”. Consumer trust is a critical factor in marketing and for this reason, leveraging the thoughts, words, and images of real human being, with their permission, through user-generated content websites, can make brand, even tourism brand and destination, trustworthy.

In this context, our paper focuses on the implications of travelers’ use of these websites for the marketing of tourism services and destinations. First of all, a literature review was performed to illustrate the impact of UGC travel-related websites for tourism marketing. Then, a quantitative study was conducted for exploring consumers’ views on UGC in relation to travel planning. The aim of this web-based survey was to investigate how UGC websites are being used by Romanian young people and the impact that these websites are having on the information search and travel behavior of the Romanian tourists. In the end, our paper explains the impact of user-generated content on the travel decision-making behavior of the Romanian travelers, provides recommendations on how the travel and tourism industry from Romania may respond to the UGC phenomena to effectively meet the needs of the tourists and proposes ways in which UGC features can be integrated into Romanian travel websites for promoting our country as a tourism destination.

Key words: user-generated content (UGC), web 2.0, social media, tourism marketing, travel planning.

JEL classification: L83, M31.

1 Introduction

Social media has essentially revolutionized our communication patterns and behaviour through the Internet, thus creating a new medium in which we consume and disseminate information (Kaplan and Haenlein, 2010). *Social media* generally refers to web applications that allow users to post and share content, such as Facebook, Twitter, Flickr, and MySpace (Lange-Faria and Elliot, 2011). One classification scheme of social media applications proposed by Kaplan and Haenlein (2010) specifies the following six categories: social networking websites (i.e. Facebook, LinkedIn), blogs, user generated content websites (i.e. YouTube, Flickr, Scrib, Slideshare, Delicious), collaborative projects (i.e. Wikipedia, Wikitravel), virtual social worlds (i.e. Second Life), and virtual game worlds (i.e. World of Warcraft). In this paper, we will refer in particular to some specific social media tools mentioned above, namely *user-generated content* (UGC) websites.

Since *Web 2.0* (the term ‘Web 2.0’ refers to the second generation of web-based services that have gained massive popularity by letting people collaborate and share information online in previously unavailable ways) has begun to change the way consumers engage with information on the Internet, the terms *User-Generated Content (UGC)* or *Consumer-Generated Media (CGM)* are commonly used to highlight the pivotal role that individual consumers have in submitting, reviewing and responding to online content (Cox et al., 2008). In the *tourism industry*, as stated by other authors (Cox et al, 2008), *UGC websites* provide a wealth of information with regards to experiences and review of the destination, property, facilities and restaurants. While travellers appear to be embracing the concept, travel industry members are still unsure of how to respond. From this perspective, this article attempts to propose solutions for the use of these instruments in *tourism marketing*. However, any attempt to integrate UGC features into existing websites should be done with the

concerns of travellers in mind. Thus, *the aim of this study* was to investigate how these specific websites are being used by tourists and the impact that these websites are having on the information search and travel behavior of these people.

In the first part of our article a *review of the literature* is provided to illustrate the ways in which these online tools are impacting on the behavior of travelers. Following on from the review of existing research, the article then presents the results of an *exploratory research* that analyzes the usage of social media among Romanian young people in their travel planning process. In this article are explored and discussed only those aspects of our extended research that are related to UGC websites and have relevance in correlation with tourism marketing. The *web-based survey* used for our research focuses on understanding how travelers use UGC in travel planning process, how much they trust in this type of online tools when planning a trip and how these websites used as information sources influence their travel behavior.

This article highlights both *the benefits and issues* regarding the *authenticity and credibility* of UGC websites as information sources. The article concludes with a discussion of the *implications of the research* related to the impact of user-generated content on the travel decision-making behavior of the Romanian travelers. Also, our article provides *recommendations* for the travel and tourism industry from Romania and proposes ways in which UGC features can be integrated into Romanian travel websites for promoting our country as a tourism destination.

2 The role of UGC in tourism marketing

Content sharing media, ranging from instant messaging, through interactive Web 2.0 media like online photo albums, personal blogs, specialist travel blogs and social network sites, have greatly expanded the potential audience beyond traditional family and friends to new, geographically dispersed networks of strangers (Lo et al., 2011). Recent research (De Ascaniis

and Morasso, 2011) suggests that UGC become very important for the reputation of a destination because is the opposite to traditional forms of media and marketing since content is generated by the consumer rather than by the marketer.

They are, in fact, written reports of people's tales about their travel experience and, from one side, they can be used to verify the actual reputation of a destination and, from the other side, they contribute fixing such a reputation. UGC is related to the digital transformation of objects: texts, sounds and images. UGC is the foundation of social media (Manap and Adzharudin, 2013). UGC includes social sharing of opinions through blogs and micro blogs (i.e. Blogger and Twitter), social photo and video sharing (i.e. Flickr and YouTube), social sharing of knowledge (i.e. Wikipedia), social bookmarking (i.e. Delicious) (Parra-Lopez et al., 2011).

UGC sites can equate to electronic WOM (word-of-mouth) marketing, whereby somebody who has an opinion about a product or service shares their views, beliefs and experiences with other people (Ahuja et al., 2007).

There is a diverse range of sites emerging that contain user-generated content related to travel and tourism. These range from generic social networking sites such as MySpace.com which contain travel sections through individual blogs that have been created by avid travellers to showcase destination reviews globally. In relation to travel and tourism, some examples of user-generated content include (Burgess et al., 2009): ordinary people sharing their opinions about travel destinations, attractions and accommodation properties through Internet; travellers submitting photos or videos to the Internet to share their travel experiences with other online users (including family, friends or total strangers who may be interested); consumers posting reviews of accommodation properties to sites such as Tripadvisor.com; people using social networking sites such as Myspace.com, Facebook.com or Youtube.com to share travel information.

A good understanding of the quality and quantity of the mechanisms for spreading information online can facilitate hotel or any other tourism related company to market effectively their own organization online.

The Web is shifting from a *business-to-consumer marketing* to a *peer-to-peer model* for the sharing of information. All tourism businesses are thus facing the need to implement strategies and tools based on user generated contents or, at least, to incorporate these new technologies to enrich their multimedia contents (Miguéns et al., 2008). Strategic marketing of a tourism based business must harness the potential of UGC. For a business in the tourism industry this means reaching out to potential clients across the changing online landscape. It means engaging people using a variety of online tools and providing information that is timely.

3 Web-based survey regarding the use of UGC websites in the travel planning process – methodology, results and discussions

A *research* has been carried out in order to explore the ways in which tourists use UGC websites for decision making process. The results presented here are a part of an extended research used for analyze *the usage of social media among Romanian* young people in their travel planning process. Our conducted research might be useful for understanding the usage of new media in tourism marketing.

The *sample* was made up of students and master students enrolled at Faculty of Commerce from Bucharest University of Economic Studies during the second semester of the 2012-2013 academic year and an e-mail invitation containing a link to the online questionnaire was sent to them. The *online questionnaire* was designed using *Google Docs*. The questionnaire included the *assignment* that respondents must be used online sources in the recent year (general, not necessarily specific travel-related websites), but related to the tourism activities undertaken by them. Recipients of the online invitation chosen to participate in the survey on a voluntary and anonymous basis. Data was

collected over a *two weeks period* in May 2013 and the questionnaire took approximately *10 minutes* to complete. As a result, a total of *106 subjects* participated in this web-based survey. All data received was converted into SPSS (*Statistical Package for the Social Sciences*) for further analysis.

Results of the questionnaire have revealed that the respondents' *age is between 19 and 28 years* (most of them (34%) were aged 24 years), most were *female* (75% of the respondents) and most interviewed students are *employed* (part-time and even full time). The respondents indicated in majority (47% of the responses) that they *generally travel 2-3 times per year*, *only in Romania* (52% of the responses) or *both in Romania and abroad* (41% of the responses) or *even only abroad* (7%), most of the time as *leisure travel* (60% of the responses), *for visiting relatives/friends* (34%) or *for business or other issues* (6%).

Most of the Facebook users surveyed have an account in other social media platforms. The students were asked about the social media tools ordinary used and they indicated *online networks and communities* (as Facebook - 58% of the responses, Google+ - 12%, LinkedIn - 10% or Twitter - 6%) and *UGC (user-generated content) websites*, with photo/video/audio/documents sharing features (like Youtube - 56% of the responses, Scribd - 20%, Instagram - 11%, Slideshare - 6%, Pinterest - 4% and Flickr - 3%), as is shown in the figure 1.

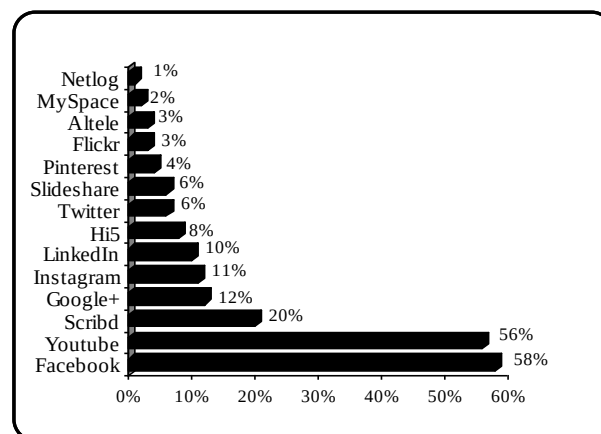


Figure 1: The social media websites ordinary used by Romanian young people

It is worthy of note that most of these mentioned platforms were used by the respondents for 3-5 years (45% of the respondents indicated this answer) or even *more than 5 years* (for 40% of the respondents).

We mention that our questionnaire included a statement explaining the term „*social media*” and the fact that *user-generated content* (defined as the aggregation and leveraging of users’ content on the Internet) is a social media tool and thus becomes a part of the social media phenomenon. Thus, students were questioned strict about the frequency of the usage of different *content sharing sites* (such as those listed above in this category) for specific information when planning a trip and they said, mostly, that these online platforms were *sometimes* or *rarely* used, as can be seen in the figure 2.

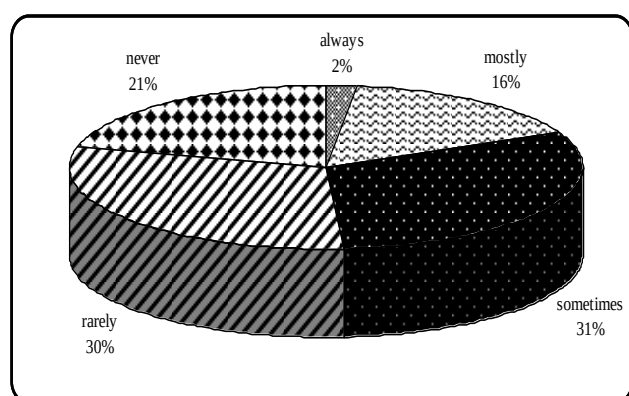


Figure 2: The use of UGC websites as information sources in the travel planning process

We must emphasize the importance of the finding that *very few respondents always use UGC tools* when they plan a trip, but also it has to be mentioned here that leisure tourists reported the greatest use of these social media websites, confirming the findings of other research (Treer, 2010).

Therefore, *other online sources* (as travelers’ online reviews, forums, blogs, resorts and hotels websites, booking websites etc.) and *offline/traditional sources* (as radio, TV, newspapers/magazines, brochures/flyers, travel guides or opinions of the relatives, friends and acquaintances) were used by Romanian young

people for travel planning process, as is shown in the table 1.

Table 1: The distribution of responses regarding the use of online and offline sources in the travel planning process

Source \ Frequency	always	mostly	sometimes	rarely	never
travel agencies websites	33%	40%	14%	9%	4%
establishments sites	37%	44%	11%	7%	1%
travel websites	14%	35%	37%	10%	4%
blogs	8%	12%	32%	33%	15%
forums	7%	24%	33%	25%	11%
official national sites	16%	34%	36%	13%	1%
travelers reviews	20%	38%	33%	7%	2%
TV	4%	8%	41%	31%	17%
Radio	2%	4%	17%	41%	37%
newspapers/magazines	1%	15%	38%	35%	11%
brochures/flyers	10%	23%	44%	18%	5%
travel guides	14%	31%	29%	22%	4%
travel agencies	23%	27%	26%	20%	4%
travel fairs	8%	15%	31%	32%	13%
friends/relatives	18%	53%	27%	2%	0%

Regarding the use of other online sources than UGC websites, it is important to mention that a significant number of respondents *always* use *accommodation establishments websites* (including here even accommodation establishments listed in booking websites - 37% of the responses) and *travel agencies/tour operators websites* (33%), so even more than the percentage of those who *sometimes* use user-generated content websites). Also, the *reviews of other travelers* (regardless of the websites where these comments are posted) are used as information source most of the time when Romanians plan to go on a trip, but *travel websites* (as portals or online travel guides) and *official websites* (i.e. web pages of national tourism organizations) are only *sometimes* used in such situations. Unexpected, many respondents stated that they *never* used *blogs* (15% of the responses) or *specialized forums* (11%) for planning travel process, in contrary to results of other research (as Rodríguez, 2009) that indicate these online information sources among the most used in such purposes.

Also, *offline sources* (as radio, TV, newspapers/magazines, brochures/flyers, etc.) were used by Romanian young people for travel planning process, as is shown in the figure 3.

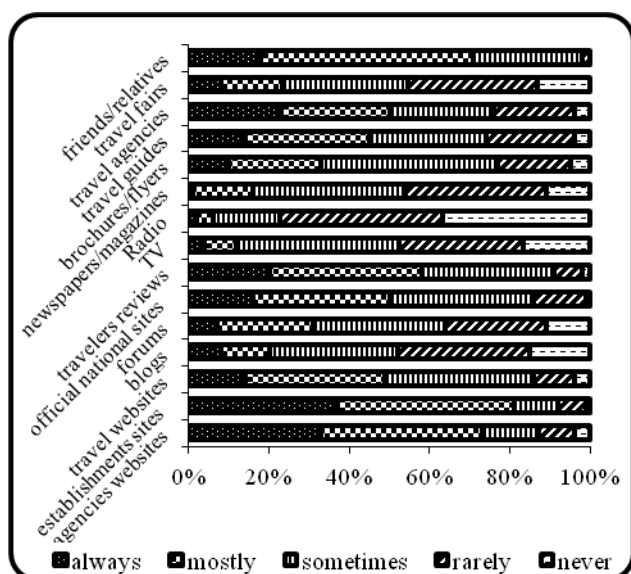


Figure 3: Traditional/offline and online information sources used by Romanian young people in the travel planning process

We noticed that most of these traditional sources are *sometimes* used in order to inform in the travel planning process. Also, we noticed that respondents rely *most of the time* on *opinions/recommendations of friends, relatives and acquaintances* for planning a trip (53% of the responses) and that many respondents stated that they *never used radio* (37% of the responses) or *TV* (17%) as information sources for travel planning process.

Making a *parallel analysis between the use of online and traditional/offline sources*, using *SPSS (Statistical Package for the Social Sciences) functions*, we noticed that many of the respondents who *always (or most of the time)* use *travel agencies/tour operators websites*, fall back on *classic travel agencies* with approximately the same frequency (actually crossing the threshold, dialoguing with their travel agents, informing about their tourism offers etc.). Likewise, we have found that many of the respondents who *always (or most of the time)* use *other travelers reviews* posted on the Internet rely in the same way and with

approximately the same frequency on *the opinions and advices of friends/relatives* in the travel planning process.

Using questions where multiple answers can be selected we asked the students about the purposes of using social media websites in the travel planning process. More specifically, our respondents searched online for ideas on *where to go for holidays* (for instance, 18% of the responses indicated the use social networks and UGC websites for choosing accommodation establishment and 16% of the responses indicated the use of these online tools for seek ideas and information regarding landmarks) and *how to get there* (for example, 12% of the responses indicated the use of these online sources for establishing route/itinerary and 11% of the responses indicated that Romanian young people use this kind of websites for choosing the transport company when they decided to go on a trip). So, it is not surprising that regarding the phase of the travel planning process when they especially used these online information sources, the respondents mentioned they used *mostly before the trip* (96% of the responses), as is shown in the figure 4.

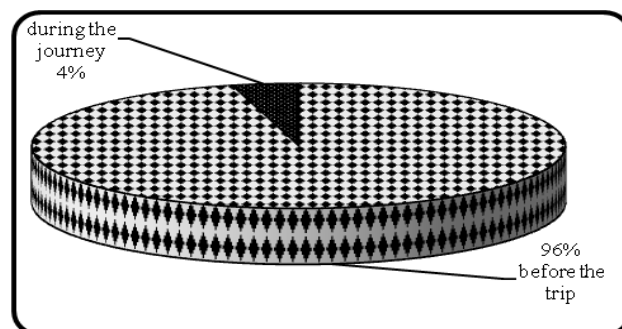


Figure 4: The use of social media as information sources in the phases of the travel planning process

We noted that there was absolutely no response to indicate the use of these online tools after the trip. This results conflicts with what was suggested by Fotis et al. (2012) who demonstrated that social media websites are *predominantly used after the trip*, especially for posting photos from their trip and sharing impressions after returning from travels, but our respondents indicated that they mainly use UGC

websites to view or download the content posted by other users, as can be seen in figure 5.

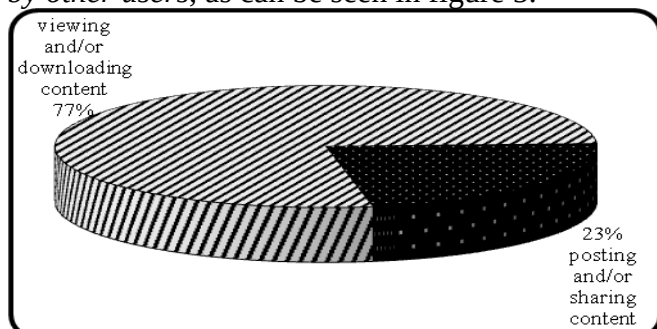


Figure 5: The purposes of using UGC websites in the travel planning process

Incentives are needed to encourage consumers to use travel reviews in later stages of their travel-decision making process, during the trip, and after returning.

Also, the survey asked respondents to indicate their level of agreement or disagreement to one statement (namely: “In case of a travel planning, social media - including here UGC websites - is a more reliable information source than traditional/offline information sources”) by using a 5 point scale. The questioned students indicated in majority (37% of the respondents) that social media is a more reliable information source, but many of those surveyed (29%) were not agreed with the statement mentioned above, as is shown in the figure 6.

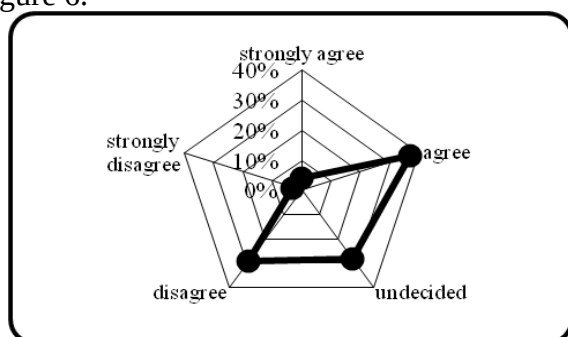


Figure 6: Level of agreement/disagreement to the statement: “In case of travel planning process, social media is a more reliable information source than traditional/offline information sources”

Our respondents think that some of the information available through social media can be relied on but some may not be credible and they see this lack of credibility as a

disadvantage of the social media. The key concern identified by the respondents who disagree with the above sentence is the multitude of false information that can be found on the Internet and can cause erroneous choices.

4 The implications of the research for tourism marketing

This research can be used by tourism operators, state tourism websites, destination marketing organizations, accommodation providers and online content providers for understanding the implications of consumers’ use of these sites for the marketing of tourism services and destinations.

UGC is seen as an ‘add-on’ that could supplement existing types of travel information provided on specific travel websites, rather than as a substitute for other forms of content. These sites can provide information that influences the final booking plans associated with travel.

Our research has shown that respondents mainly use UGC websites mostly before the trip to view or download the content posted by other users, so UGC can be exploited by the tourism industry in Romania in the pre-trip phase of travel planning for real information through social media, which can lead the traveler towards choosing the destination. The ability of UGC tools to convert consumers from ‘observers’ to ‘purchasers’ due to the trustworthiness of consumer reviews must be exploited. Marketers need to recognise that business’s underlying reason for attempting to engage with sites containing user-generated content should be to build an online relationship with their target market, rather than simply to manipulate advertising messages (Cherian, 2007). It is recommended that marketers should work towards joining their consumers in honest conversation rather than trying to control them through traditional forms of advertising. Travel operators and other tourism organisations must not attempt to manipulate content or add ‘fake’ postings which masquerade as real travellers as many users see right through these tactics and form

negative opinions about organizations that tamper with UGC.

Romanian young people just need to be more involved in social media, to bring more contribution in all stages of planning a trip. Incentives are needed to *encourage consumers to use travel reviews in later stages of their travel-decision making process*, during the trip, and after returning. Making it easy and efficient for people to contribute, reminding them that others helped them and that they can now help others after returning home seem to be critical in increasing the extent to which consumers contribute. Specifically, travel service providers can send *reminder e-mails* that directly link to a Web space where the *review can be posted*.

As we have shown in this paper, a significant number of respondents in our research *always* use *accommodation establishments' websites* and *travel agencies/tour operators' websites* as information sources in the travel planning process, but analyzing the e-tourism sector in Romania we found that these websites do not entirely capitalize the possibilities offered by UGC tools. *Accommodation establishments* must integrate *travellers' stories* as the central component of its online site (Bray, 2006) because this enable readers to comment on their experiences with the hotel, but it also actively encourages readers to *share* their travel experiences more broadly with other site users. As indicated by other studies (Cox et al., 2008), travellers prefer websites that allow them to enter *ratings* for individual travel experiences and *accommodation establishments websites* should offer this possibility. Even if hoteliers are not integrating user-generated content into their online marketing strategies, at least they should be establishing systems to enable the *ongoing monitoring of content posted* on these sites regarding their properties (Bressler, 2007). Likewise, *travel agencies* must engage with Web 2.0 to enhance their communications with their customers, for example by combining information from travel industry experts with *real content from real travellers* or by establishing an area within their website that travellers at all stages of their holiday planning

process can *communicate* with one another through *postings, reviews and sharing* of images and video content (Bentley, 2007).

UGC can also prove valuable to businesses as a *market research tool* (Cox et al., 2008). Contributors should be asked to provide some profile information to enable readers to make informed decisions about how relevant postings are to their own situations. Given the obvious freedom of information that UGC sites provides to consumers, businesses should realise their potential for conducting *webnographic research*. *Webnography* or *web-ethnography* is an attempt to look for insights arising from natural contexts on the Internet – the natural conversations among consumers, or what we refer to as consumer generated media. This includes forums, blogs, newsgroups, social networking services, message boards, consumer reviews etc. (Puri, 2007).

Although our research showed that many classical sources are used more in detriment of those online, though the classical ones may help straighten attention to online sources. For example, QR codes are an excellent way to add a *web call to action* to print media such as brochures or flyers.

Also, it is grave that web pages of national tourism organizations are used only by few Romanian young people when searching online information. Regarding this type of websites, either using the travel reviews' sites as *promotional channel* or *allowing traveler reviews* on their official homepage are possible ways to benefiting from UGC. Utilizing the power of Web 2.0, smart destinations are encouraging their residents, local businesses, visitors and third party suppliers tell the *destination story*.

5 Conclusions

Based on the *literature review* and our *exploratory research*, it can be concluded that *UGC websites* plays the role of an additional source of information that travelers consider as part of their search information process, rather than as the only source of information. Even so,

Romanians see clear advantages in *consumer-generated content websites* as information sources, are highly influenced by other *travelers' reviews* and appreciate the detail and relevance of information provided by *travel service providers*.

The study presented here is a confirmation of the importance that user-generated content may have in *promoting single operators and the destination as a whole*.

While tourists are undoubtedly responding well to the emergence of user-generated content regarding travel, the tourism industry itself has been cited as being somewhat slower than other sectors to adopt UGC (Bray, 2006) and in Romania the value of UGC perhaps has been under-valued. Tourism operators and destination marketing organisations cannot afford to ignore the growing popularity of websites using UGC because UGC offers significant *business benefits*, despite concerns about travel-related UGC such as contributor anonymity, subjectivity of opinions, honesty and accuracy of content.

References

- Ahuja, R.D., Michels, T.A., Walker, M.M. and Weissbuch, M. (2007), Teen perceptions of disclosure in buzz marketing, *Journal of Consumer Marketing*, 24 (3): 151–159.
- Bentley, R. (2007), Join the revolution, *Travel Weekly*, vol. 1865: 70-71.
- Bray, J. (2006), Web 2.0 Begins to Sprout in Travel, *PhoCusWright*, www.phocuswright.com/research_updates/web-20-begins-to-sprout-in-travel, Accessed 8 September 2013.
- Bressler, H. (2007), Managing Hotel Guest Complaints on User-generated Travel Website, *COM Marketing*, www.commarketing.com/managing-hotel-guest-complaints.html, Accessed 8 September 2013.
- Burgess, S., Sellitto, C., Cox, C. and Buultjens, J. (2009), User-Generated Content (UGC) in tourism: benefits and concerns of online consumers, *17th European Conference on Information Systems*, Vienna, <http://www.ecis2009.it/papers/ecis2009-0121.pdf>, Accessed 2 September 2013.
- Cherian, T. (2007), Consumer Generated Marketing ideally suited to the hospitality sector, *Businessline*, 7: 1-20;
- Cox, C., Burgess, S., Sellitto, C. and Buultjens, J. (2008), *Users are doing it for themselves: how consumer-generated content is changing the face of tourism marketing*, Sustainable Tourism Cooperative Research Centre (STCRC), Gold Coast: Styleprint Qld.
- De Ascaniis, S. And Greco Morasso, S., (2011), When tourists give their reasons on the web: The argumentative significance of tourism related UGC. In: R. Law, M. Fuchs, F. Ricci, *Information and Communication Technologies in Tourism 2011* (pp 125-137). Vienna: Springer-Verlag.
- Kaplan, A.M. and Haenlein, M. (2010), Users of the world, unite! The challenges and opportunities of Social Media, *Business Horizons*, 53(1): 59-68.
- Fotis, J., Buhalis, D. and Rossides, N. (2012), Social media use and impact during the holiday travel planning process. In: M. Fuchs, F. Ricci, and L. Cantoni, *Information and Communication Technologies in Tourism* (pp. 13-24). Vienna: Springer-Verlag.
- Lange-Faria, W. and Elliot, S. (2012), Understanding the role of social media in destination marketing, *Tourismos: An International Multidisciplinary Journal Of Tourism*, 7 (1): 193-211.
- Lo, I. S., McKercher, B., Lo, A., Cheung, C. and Law, R. (2011), Tourism and online photography, *Tourism Management*, 32 (4): 725-731.
- Manap, K.H.A. and Adzharudin, N.A. (2013), The Role of User Generated Content (UGC) in Social Media for Tourism Sector. In *The 2013 WEI International Academic Conference Proceedings* (pp.52-58). Istanbul: The West East Institute.
- Miguéns, J., Baggio, R. and Costa, C. (2008), *Social media and Tourism Destinations: TripAdvisor Case Study*, IASK ATR Advances in Tourism Research. <http://www.iby.it/turismo/papers/baggio-aveiro2.pdf>, Accessed 24 July 2013.
- Parra-Lopez, E., Bulchand-Gidumal, J., Gutierrez-Tano, D. and Diaz-Armas, R. (2011), Intentions to use social media in organizing and taking vacation trips, *Computers in Human Behaviour*, 27(2): 640-654.
- Puri, A. (2007), The web of insights: The art and practice of webnography, *International Journal of Market Research*, 49 (3): 387-408.
- Rodríguez, I.R. (2009), *Social Media in Tourism Behaviour*, Bournemouth University and Université de Savoie, <http://du.se/PageFiles/18846/RodrguezIreneLucena.pdf>, Accessed 24 July 2013.
- Treer, E. (2010), *Social media: an interesting option for tourism destination promotion?*, Aalborg University, <http://projekter.aau.dk/projekter>, Accessed 24 July 2013.